UNIT 11

Later Cholas and Pandyas

Learning Objectives

The objectives of the lesson are to enable students to acquire knowledge of

I Cholas

- The achievements of Chola rulers
- Cultural developments in the Chola region
- Emergence of well-developed agrarian structure and irrigation system
- Role of temples in medieval Tamil society
- Maritime trade during Chola period

II Pandyas

- Rise of Pandyas with Madurai as their capital
- Malik Kafur's invasion and its fallout
- Succession dispute inviting the attention of Sultan Alauddin Khalji
- Agriculture, irrigation and trade during the Pandya rule
- Religion and culture in southern Tamil Nadu

Introduction

The Cholas belonged to one of the three mighty dynasties that ruled the Tamizh country in the early historical period. Described as the Muvendhar in the Sangam literature, they were known for the valour and for their patronage of the Tamil language. Many songs were composed in high praise of their glories. However, after the Sangam period until about the ninth century CE, there are no records about them. Changes that overtook Tamizhagam in the intervening period brought about a major transformation of the region and enabled the emergence of big, long-lasting monarchical states. The Cholas were one among them.

The river valleys facilitated the expansion of agriculture leading to the emergence of powerful kingdoms. The agricultural boom resulted in the production of surplus food grains. But this surplus in production resulted in unequal distribution of wealth. Society gradually became highly differentiated unlike in the earlier period. Institutions and ideas from the north of India, such as the temple and the religion it represented, emerged as a new force. The Bhakti movement led by the Nayanmars and Azhwars popularised the ideology and the faith they represented. Similarly, political ideas and institutions that originated in the northern India soon found their way to the south as well. The cumulative result of all the new developments was the formation of a state, which in this case was a monarchy presided over by the descendants of the old Chola lineage.

After the eclipse of the Chola kingdom, Pandyas, who began their rule in the Vaigai river basin at Madurai, wielded tremendous power during the 14th century. Like the Cholas, the Pandyas also realised substantial revenue from

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